

DANIEL DREW

1797–1879

One of the more notorious characters of Wall Street, Daniel Drew was a complex man who never hesitated to enter into a dubious money-making scheme, but also founded a major theological seminary and taught Sunday School himself. Drew grew up on a farm in rural Carmel, New York. School was a luxury (and not an option), so he made extra money for the family by working for circuses that had their winter quarters nearby; no doubt he learned a few tricks from the hucksters that would prove profitable later in life. His father died in 1812, and Drew, only 14, joined the army as a substitute, collecting \$100 in the process. Eventually, he would peddle that money into more than \$16 million.

His first line of business was buying cattle on credit and then driving them into places like New York City, where he sold them to the butchers. Even then, he pulled a trick or two, according to Henry Clews, who noted: "By the way, the significant term of 'watering stock' originated in the practice of Uncle Daniel giving his cattle salt in order to create a thirst in them that would cause them to imbibe large quantities of water, and thus appear bigger and fatter when brought to market." As an aside, he started acting as a banker for the other drovers, and that was the beginning of his involvement with Wall Street. In 1836, he formed a brokerage house, Drew, Robinson and Company.

Drew became an expert at making money in falling markets, and was known to incite a panic or two. One writer of the time said: "Drew is a most robust architect of panics. . . . Well too does he deserve the title of 'merry old gentleman' of Wall Street. In his most earnest operations he never seems to lose sight of 'the fun of the thing.' " In *Daniel Drew on Wall Street*, written in Drew's voice by Bouck White, one of his merry adventures with Jay Gould and Jim Fisk is described along with the lessons learned. White, who wrote *The Book of Daniel Drew*, claimed that he found a trunk full of Drew's notes and used them as a source for Drew's "autobiography." Whether this was true or not, one historian determined that "the basic facts and the flavor of the narrative were indisputably authentic."